Twelve Everyday Routines and Choices to Notice, and Ask Your Loved One About

What to notice over a few ordinary days, what to write down, and a question to ask them about each.

With a decision close, the family is talking about your loved one's care. This guide is about something quieter: how their ordinary days go. It names twelve routines and choices worth noticing and, for each, what to write down and a question to ask them.

Notice, write down, then ask. Don't decide that a routine matters to them because you saw it; that is what the question is for. Walking through a person's day, their rituals and routines, and their good days and bad days comes from a person-centered practice guide published by the federal Administration for Community Living. Writing down a person's own words comes from the Institute for Healthcare Improvement. Both were written for professionals. The wording about what to notice and write down is ours.

How the day starts and ends

1 The first hour [1]

NOTICE What they do first and in what order: the coffee, the radio, the paper, the chair by the window.

WRITE DOWN The order as you saw it, and what they say when you ask: “What part of your morning would you least want changed?”

2 The last hour [1]

NOTICE How the evening winds down: a program, a phone call, a book, when the light goes off.

WRITE DOWN What a usual evening looks like, and what they say when you ask: “What makes an evening feel like your own?”

Through the day

3 Meals and the kitchen [3]

NOTICE What they like to cook or eat, where they sit, whether a meal is company or quiet time.

WRITE DOWN A typical day's meals and who made them, and what they say when you ask: “Which meals do you look forward to?”

4 Their own spot

NOTICE The chair, the porch, the workbench, the side of the bed: the places they go back to by choice.

WRITE DOWN Where they spend their time, and what they say when you ask: “Where do you most like to be during the day?”

5 What they decide for themselves

NOTICE The small decisions in a day: when to get up, what to wear, what's on the television, when to have visitors.

WRITE DOWN The choices they make without anyone asking, and what they say when you ask: “Which of these do you most want to keep deciding yourself?”

6 A good day and a bad day [1] [4]

NOTICE What was going on the last time they seemed most like themselves, and on a day that went badly.

WRITE DOWN Two columns, good day and bad day, filled in with their words when you ask: “What does a good day look like for you?”

The week and the year

7 Standing dates [1]

NOTICE The things that happen every week or month: a service, a card game, the hairdresser, a Sunday call with a grandchild.

WRITE DOWN What's on their calendar and how they get there, and what they say when you ask: “Which of these would you hate to miss?”

8 Days that matter [1]

NOTICE Birthdays, anniversaries, holidays, the gathering they host or never miss.

WRITE DOWN The dates and what they do on them, and what they say when you ask: “Which days in the year matter most to you?”

People

9 The people they see

NOTICE Who visits, who they call, and whose company they seem to enjoy most.

WRITE DOWN Names and how often, and what they say when you ask: “Who would you like to see more of?”

10 Who they lean on [4]

NOTICE Who or what they turn to when something is hard: a relative, a neighbor, a friend, a pet, their faith.

WRITE DOWN Who or what it is, and what they say when you ask: “Who or what supports you when times are difficult?”

11 What they do for others [2]

NOTICE Minding a grandchild, volunteering, driving a neighbor to the store, remembering everyone's birthday.

WRITE DOWN What they do and for whom, and what they say when you ask: “What do you like doing for other people?”

In their own words

12 What they say without being asked [2]

NOTICE Remarks in passing about the house, about having help, about what they would or wouldn't want. Also the subjects they change.

WRITE DOWN Their exact words, the date and who heard them, and what they say when you ask: “You said this the other day. Can you tell me more about what you meant?”

When it's a question for their clinician

This guide is about what your loved one likes and chooses. It isn't about their health. If something you notice about their health or how they are managing concerns you, don't try to work out what it means. Tell their doctor or nurse what you saw. The National Institute on Aging's advice, when you're concerned about a person's physical or mental health, is to suggest a visit to a health care provider. In an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any routine means, which ones have to be kept, or what kind of care would fit around them. It gives you your loved one's days in their own words, ready to bring to the people who help plan their care.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed how your loved one's days go and asked them about it. The care interview sets that beside the rest of the picture, going through their situation one area at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the routines, rituals and good-day, bad-day exercises in the Administration for Community Living's person-centered thinking toolkit. Items marked 2 follow the Institute for Healthcare Improvement's guidance on asking older adults what matters, including its advice to record a person's own words. The item marked 3 follows the National Institute on Aging's example of a person who wants to keep cooking at home. The questions marked 4, about a good day and about who supports them in difficult times, are adapted from The Conversation Project's starter guide, which is written for the person themselves. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step, which asks families to record the routines and choices a person wants preserved.

1. Administration for Community Living (National Center on Advancing Person-Centered Practices and Systems), Office of Healthcare Information and Counseling Person-Centered Thinking Toolkit
2. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
3. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
4. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care